

SCIENCE IS THE PATH TO KNOWLEDGE, AND FINDING OUT ABOUT HOW OUR UNIVERSE WORKS. YOU CAN'T BE A GEEK AND NOT KNOW YOUR SCIENCE!

HAVE YOU EVER...?

THIS MONTH IN SCIENCE:

Ever wondered how a coma is different from blackouts? Ever imagined that a roller coaster ride could be a cure for kidney stones? Ever thought that some of the most innovative ideas in the country would come not from its labs, but from its startups?



There are chunks of plastic frozen in the Arctic ice

A British-led expedition has found sizable chunks of polystyrene on remote frozen ice flows in the middle of Arctic Ocean. The discovery was made just 1,000 miles away from the North Pole, in an area that was inaccessible to scientists because of sea ice. <http://dgit.in/polyarctic>

WHAT'S NEW

The fear of spiders and snakes is hereditary

A lot of people are afraid of snakes and spiders, even in countries and places where people hardly come in contact with them. A debate going on for a while now is whether this fear is innate or learnt.

Scientists at the Max Planck Institute for Human Cognitive Brain Sciences (MPICBS) in Leipzig and the Uppsala University have discovered that the fear is indeed hereditary and ingrained in us.

Even six month old babies felt stressed upon seeing the creatures, long before they could have possibly learned to be afraid of them.

Even in a country like Germany, where a very



small percentage of the population is exposed to snakes or spiders and the country is only known to have two species of snakes that are truly venomous, the percentage of people who are averse to the creatures is no less than any other country where they are more commonplace.

<http://dgit.in/fearcrawlies>

Puppy dog eyes are meant only for humans

A new study shows that dogs make puppy dog eyes solely for the benefit of humans. It was found that the facial expression is rarely ever used outside of when they're interacting with humans.

It was long assumed that animal facial expressions were involuntary and dependant on emotional state. It wasn't thought that dogs used it as a form of communication.



However, scientists at the Dog Cognition Centre at Portsmouth University have found that dogs mostly use facial expressions when

humans are present, as a direct response to attention.

The "puppy dog eyes", where the dog raises its brows and makes its eyes appear wider was found to be the most common. Researchers haven't been able to tell if the dogs actually know that they look sadder, or if they've just learned that doing so elicits sympathy and affection from humans.

<http://dgit.in/pupeyes>



Source: NASA

Water could have flowed on ancient Mars

Mars has water-carved valleys and lake beds which indicate that at some point water flowed on its surface. However, climate models suggest that average temperatures on the red planet stayed well below freezing. So how was water flow possible?

<http://dgit.in/marswaterflow>



British birds evolved bigger beaks

It has been found that some birds in Britain have evolved to have bigger beaks over the last 40 years. The reason? It's easier to feed from bird-feeders, which is fairly commonplace in Britain and can be found in many places.

<http://dgit.in/britbird>



Crops evolved ten millennia before what experts thought

According to a new research by the University of Warwick, ancient hunter-gatherers affected the evolution of crops up to 30,000 years ago, which is a good 10,000 years before experts previously estimated.

<http://dgit.in/cropevolve>